

Interviewer Effect Simulation Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 30-40 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	interviewer-effect-simulation

Big idea: In human sciences, the person asking can become part of the evidence produced.

Overview

Students conduct mini-interviews with different interviewer styles and compare how method shapes responses.

Student Prompt

Inspect Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Question: 'How useful is homework for learning?' Styles: warm, rushed, leading, skeptical, neutral. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Question: 'What makes a classroom discussion good?' Styles: encouraging, distracted, formal. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Interviewer Effect Simulation Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Question: 'What makes a classroom discussion good?' Styles: encouraging, distracted, formal. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — In human sciences, the person asking can become part of the evidence produced.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	How can data be shaped by the method used to collect it?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how in human sciences, the person asking can become part of the evidence produced.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Use safe topics such as homework routines, cafeteria preferences, or study environments.
- Assign interviewer styles openly so students can analyze method rather than feel manipulated.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Question: 'How useful is homework for learning?' Styles: warm, rushed, leading, skeptical, neutral.
- Question: 'What makes a classroom discussion good?' Styles: encouraging, distracted, formal.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Pairs receive the same interview question but different interviewer style cards.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Students conduct short, low-stakes interviews.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Respondents reflect on how the style affected their answer.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Groups compare differences in length, confidence, and content.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief interviewer effects and research reliability.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- The question is not the only method; the social situation is part of the method.
- How did the interviewer change what felt safe or relevant to say?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat class behaviour as universal human nature.
- Students may ignore ethical limits or context effects in human-subject inquiry.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Connects behaviour to method, context, incentives, and ethical constraints.
- Avoids overgeneralising from one small sample.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use two interviewer styles.
- Challenge: add inter-rater coding of response detail.

Extension Tasks

- Students design a better interview protocol with ethics notes.
- Compare interviews with surveys, observation, and experiments.

Related Activities

- Observer Effect Roleplay
- Survey Wording Experiment
- Conformity without Humiliation